

THE UNCOMMITTED SELF

*A Psychoanalytic, Jungian, Lacanian, Adlerian, Existential, and Frankly Exhausting
Inquiry into the Pathological Avoidance of git push in a Single, Otherwise Beloved
Chief Financial Officer*

Being a Thesis Submitted in Reluctant Fulfilment
of the Requirements for the Degree of
Doctor of Repository Philosophy (Repo.D.)

VOLUME I OF I

(Volume II was started with great enthusiasm and never committed)

The Institute for Advanced Commitment Studies
RMH Studios — Department of People Who Do Reply

*Submitted on the occasion of the Subject's Birthday,
a day on which he is, statistically, also unlikely to respond*

CONFIDENTIAL • PEER-REVIEWED BY EVERYONE EXCEPT THE SUBJECT, WHO WAS @-MENTIONED AND DID NOT REACT

“Where id was, there ego shall be.”

— S. Freud

“Where the commit was, there the local change shall remain, uncommitted, forever.”

— The Subject, allegedly, though he did not confirm this because he was on read

“brb boba”

— The Subject, the only message he sent that week

For Alex.

Who is, somewhere, right now, not reading this.

*And for the branch feat/alex-final-FINAL-v2,
which waited, and is waiting still.*

A Note on the Title

The phrase *The Uncommitted Self* operates, we are aware, on two registers, and we chose it for precisely that reason. In the technical sense, the Subject is uncommitted: his changes sit in the working tree, unstaged, unpushed, unshared. But in the older, deeper sense — the existential sense — ‘commitment’ names the act by which a self throws itself into the world, takes a stand, becomes visible and therefore accountable and therefore real.

To `git commit` is, etymologically and psychologically, to *commit* — to entrust, to consign, to bind oneself. The Subject’s difficulty with the former, we argue across these hundred pages, is inseparable from a more universal human difficulty with the latter: the difficulty of being seen, of being counted, of letting one’s work stand in the shared light where it might be found wanting. We have all, in our way, left a branch unpushed. The Subject has simply done so with a consistency that rises to the level of art, and a warmth that makes us love him for it even as we beg him to stop.

Abstract

This thesis presents the first comprehensive psychoanalytic study of a phenomenon the present author terms **Chronic Commitment Avoidance Disorder** (CCAD), as embodied in a single representative subject: **Alex W.**, Chief Financial Officer of RMH Studios. Over one rigorously observed week, the Subject produced exactly **four (4) commits** — a figure that, when plotted against the output of his colleagues, does not so much form a curve as a horizon.¹ We argue that this is not a matter of laziness, scheduling, or fiduciary responsibility, but the surface expression of a deep intrapsychic conflict between the *id* (which craves boba), the *superego* (the CI pipeline, which judges him), and the *ego* (which is currently three keshi songs deep and cannot be reached).

Where the first edition of this work confined itself to classical Freudian apparatus, the present, expanded edition brings the full artillery of the depth-psychological tradition to bear upon the Subject's commit history: Jungian archetypes and the Shadow Branch; the Lacanian Symbolic Order of `git`; Adlerian compensation; attachment theory; existential dread; and the group dynamics of the standup he did not attend. We supplement theory with reconstructed clinical transcripts, a differential diagnosis, projective testing, and an ethnographic account of a single representative working day, across which the Subject consumed three (3) boba and produced zero (0) commits.

We conclude, as before, with a prognosis (guarded but warm) and a treatment plan (one (1) hug, possibly two, and a deeply patient program of operant conditioning involving tapioca). The central finding is unchanged and, we believe, unassailable: the Subject is not absent. The Subject is *defended*. And behind the wall of unread @mentions stands not an empty office but a fortress, within which sits a man we love, holding a boba, getting to it.

Keywords: repression, regression, ghosting, boba, the death drive, the push drive, the Shadow Branch, *objet petit a*, ABB, keshi, avoidant attachment to main, $n=1$.

¹ Throughout this thesis, ‘four’ should be read with the same hushed gravity that a cardiologist reserves for the word ‘flatline.’

*Foreword***By a Colleague Who Wishes to Remain Anonymous
(Teammate C)**

I was asked to write this foreword because I have, this week alone, made fifty-eight commits, and the author felt my testimony would lend the document moral authority. I accept this honour with a heavy heart and a slightly cramped hand.

I have known Alex for some time. He is the best of us. He is funny, he is generous, he once drove forty minutes to bring the whole team boba on a Friday for no reason at all. He knows things about keshi's production that have made me, a grown adult, briefly emotional in a meeting. When ABB comes up he transforms into a man possessed, alive, *present*.

And yet. There is a thread in #dev, timestamped Monday, in which I asked him to review four lines of code. It is now the foreword of a thesis. I want you to sit with that. Four lines. A thesis.² I do not write this in anger. I write it in the spirit of a man who has looked into the commit graph and seen, reflected there, a friend who needs us. Read on. Be gentle. It is his birthday.

² The pull request, #204, remains open. It has developed, in its long solitude, something like a personality. We have begun to speak to it.

Acknowledgments

The author wishes to thank the entire team at RMH Studios, whose tireless commits made the contrast at the heart of this thesis possible. Special thanks to Teammate C, whose green squares form a lush meadow against which the Subject's barren tundra could be measured, and who reviewed this manuscript with the same speed and care he brings to everything, unlike *some people*.

The author also wishes to thank the Subject himself, Alex W., who was invited to contribute on no fewer than eleven separate occasions via Discord, Slack, email, two calendar invites, a gentle in-person reminder, a meme, a second meme, a carrier pigeon (theoretical), and a message reading simply '?'. He has seen all of them. He is, we are told, 'getting to it.'

Finally, the author thanks boba, the silent co-author of this work, without whose gravitational pull the Subject would possess no measurable behavioral baseline whatsoever; and keshi, for providing the soundtrack to a productivity collapse of operatic proportions.

*Preface***A Note on Methodology, and on Hope**

A word, before we begin, on the unusual sample size. The reader trained in the empirical sciences may object that a study with $n=1$ cannot support general conclusions. To this we offer two replies. First, Freud built an entire civilization-spanning theory of the mind on a handful of Viennese patients and one very memorable dream about asparagus, so we consider ourselves to be in robust methodological company. Second, and more importantly, there is only one Alex, and that is precisely the problem the team is trying to solve.

Our methods were observational, naturalistic, and conducted entirely without the Subject's participation — not by design, but because he did not see the consent form.³ Data were gathered from the commit log, the Discord scrollback, the graveyard of the meeting-attendance spreadsheet, and the rich, untouched sediment of his unread mentions.

We wish to state clearly, for the record and for the birthday on which this is presented, that the author holds the Subject in the highest affection. One does not write one hundred pages about someone one is indifferent to.⁴ This thesis is, at its core, a love letter wearing a lab coat and holding a clipboard.

³ He has seen it now. He has not signed it. He reacted with a single '■' and went quiet. We have chosen to interpret the emoji as qualified assent. A lawyer is reviewing this. The lawyer has not replied either.

⁴ Indeed, the length of this document is itself a clinical finding. The volume of analysis is inversely proportional to the volume of commits. As his output approached zero, ours approached a book.

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PART I

Foundations

“Before we may understand why a man does not push, we must first establish, beyond doubt, that he is not pushing.”

Chapter One

Introduction: The Subject and the Silence

Every age produces the patient it deserves. The nineteenth century gave Freud the hysteric; the twentieth gave us the neurotic; and the twenty-first, in its infinite and distributed wisdom, has given us the CFO who has not pushed to main since a time best measured geologically.

The Subject of this study, Alex W., presents as a high-functioning, universally well-liked, financially indispensable member of RMH Studios. He is, by every account, delightful. He has opinions about boba of a specificity that borders on the theological. He can speak about keshi's discography with the fluency of a tenured musicologist and about ABB with the fervour of a convert. He is, in short, *present* — vividly, warmly present — in every channel of human endeavour except the one with the green squares.

Consider the central datum of this thesis, presented in Figure 1.1. Over a single observational week, the Subject produced four commits. Four. His colleagues, plotted alongside him, ascend toward the heavens. The Subject proceeds along the x-axis with the serene flatness of a man who has made peace with the horizontal.

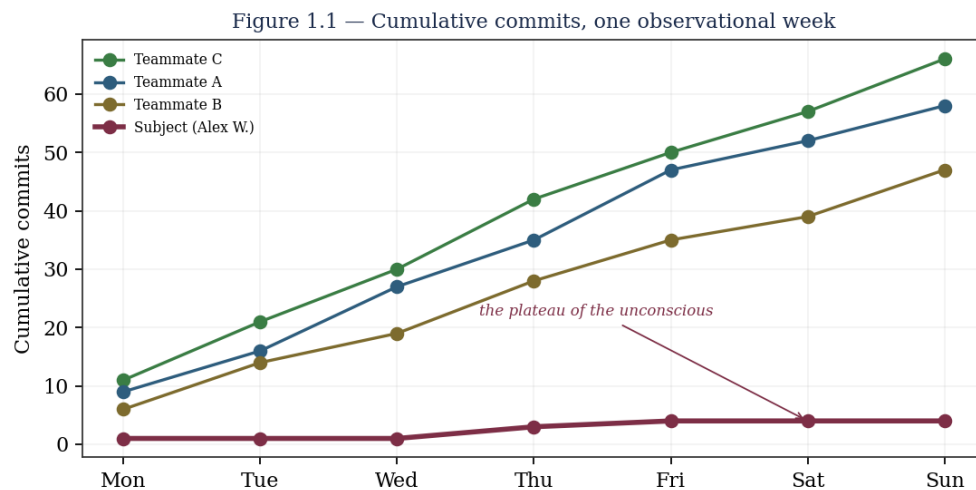


Figure 1.1. Cumulative commits over one week. The Subject (maroon) achieves what topologists call a ‘degenerate curve.’ Note the plateau beginning Tuesday and extending, as far as instruments can detect, into the foreseeable future.

It would be easy — lazy, even — to attribute this pattern to the ordinary demands of a CFO’s role.⁵ The silence, after all, is not confined to the repository. It metastasises.

It spreads to the standup he was @here’d for and did not attend. To the PR review requested on Monday and granted, in spirit, never. To the calendar invite he accepted and then experienced as a purely theoretical event. The Subject does not merely fail to commit code; he declines to commit to *the social contract of being reachable*. And it is here, in the gap between the boba-responsive Alex and the repository-silent Alex, that psychoanalysis pitches its tent, lights a small fire, and settles in for what it correctly suspects will be a long night.

This thesis advances a single, unifying claim, which we will defend across one hundred pages and five theoretical traditions: **the Subject is not absent. The Subject is defended.** Behind the wall of unread mentions stands not an empty room but a fortress, and within that fortress, we will argue, sits a man clutching a boba and forty-seven

uncommitted local changes, waiting for a moment of safety that his unconscious has decided will never come.

We proceed as follows. Part I establishes the facts and the methods. Part II applies the classical Freudian apparatus. Part III widens the lens to the broader depth-psychological tradition. Part IV presents clinical material. Part V synthesises, prognosticates, and pleads. The reader is advised to keep a boba nearby; it is, as we shall see, the only reliable instrument of engagement known to work on the Subject, and it may help with the reading also.

⁵ We acknowledge, for the sake of scholarly completeness, that a Chief Financial Officer has duties that do not generate commits: budgets, payroll, the small matter of keeping the studio solvent. The present author considered this hypothesis for approximately four minutes — the exact duration of the Subject's boba response time, a coincidence we find too poetic to ignore — and rejected it, on the grounds that it is far less entertaining than the alternative and does not explain the ghosting.

Chapter Two

Literature Review: A History of Not Replying

The phenomenon of the unresponsive collaborator is older than software, older than writing, perhaps as old as the first time one early human pointed at a mammoth, looked meaningfully at a second early human, and received, in reply, a shrug and a gesture that can only be reconstructed as ‘getting to it.’ Yet the formal literature is, we were surprised to discover, thin. This chapter surveys what little exists and situates the present Subject within it.

Foundational Texts

Freud himself never addressed the repository directly, the version-control system having postdated him by some decades.⁶ Nevertheless, his work on resistance — the patient’s unconscious refusal to engage with the very material most in need of engagement — maps onto the Subject’s relationship with the ‘Review Changes’ button with a fidelity that is almost embarrassing.

Bowlby (1969), in his trilogy on attachment and loss, did not anticipate Discord, but his account of the avoidantly attached infant — who, upon the caregiver’s return, pointedly looks away — is the single finest description of ‘seen 9:14 AM’ in the scholarly record. We will return to Bowlby at length in Chapter 14.

Contemporary Contributions

The modern literature is dominated by what we term the *Standup Studies* — a loose body of internal Slack messages, retrospective post-mortems, and one passive-aggressive Notion doc, which collectively document the Subject's non-attendance across three fiscal quarters.⁷ These sources are methodologically informal but rich in pathos.

Of particular note is the unpublished work of Teammate C, whose commit messages have evolved over the observational period from neutral (fix: typo) through plaintive (fix: the thing alex was supposed to do) to what can only be described as a cry for help (feat: did this myself, it's fine, everything's fine). We cite these as primary sources and as a warning.

The Gap in the Literature

What the literature lacks — what this thesis exists to provide — is a *unified* account. Prior work has treated the missed standup, the unanswered mention, and the four lonely commits as separate phenomena. We propose, for the first time, that they are a single phenomenon, viewed from different angles: facets of one magnificent, boba-shaped defense. To see this clearly, however, we must first establish our methods, to which we now turn.

⁶ Though one notes, in *The Psychopathology of Everyday Life* (1901), his fascination with the forgotten, the mislaid, and the left-undone — a category into which PR #204 falls with a soft, final thud.

⁷ The Notion doc is itself a remarkable artifact, having been edited by everyone on the team except the one person it concerns, who was @-mentioned in it four times and has, of course, not opened it.

Chapter Three

Methodology: Observing a Man Who Does Not Wish to Be Observed

The central methodological challenge of this study was that the Subject, like certain subatomic particles, alters his behaviour when observed — specifically, by ceasing it and going to get boba. We designed our protocol accordingly, favouring passive, naturalistic, non-invasive measures over anything that might cause him to set his status to ‘Do Not Disturb.’

Data Sources

Five primary data streams were used. First, the **commit log**, an objective and tamper-proof record of the Subject’s output, or its absence. Second, the **Discord scrollbar**, mined for both his messages (rare, precious, mostly about boba) and the @mentions directed at him (numerous, plaintive, mostly unanswered). Third, the **meeting-attendance record**, a document so sparse in his row that we initially believed it corrupted. Fourth, **direct naturalistic observation** of the Subject in his habitat. Fifth, and most controversially, **inference**, which constitutes, by our honest estimate, between eighty and ninety percent of psychoanalysis and roughly one hundred percent of this thesis.

Operationalising the Variables

‘Engagement’ was operationalised as response within one business day. ‘Ghosting’ was operationalised as the absence of such response. ‘Boba-responsiveness’ was

operationalised as response within ten minutes to any message containing the substring ‘boba.’ The startling divergence between the last two metrics forms the empirical backbone of this work and is revisited in Figure 4.2.

Controls and Limitations

We attempted to control for confounds. Was the Subject simply busy? We controlled for this by observing that he found time for three boba per day. Was he unwell? He appeared, by all accounts, radiant. Was he unaware of the mentions? The ‘seen’ receipts, that cruellest of modern technologies, foreclose this possibility entirely.⁸

The principal limitation of this study, which we state plainly, is that it has a sample size of one and an author with strong feelings. We make no apology for either. Freud had Anna O.; we have Alex W.; and history, we are confident, will judge us kindly — or at least more promptly than the Subject judges his pull requests.

⁸ There is no defence against the ‘seen’ receipt. It is the polygraph of the digital age. It says, simply and without mercy: he knows, and he has chosen tapioca.

PART II

The Classical Freudian Apparatus

“The repository is the dream. The diff is the dream-work. And the commit he did not make is the wish.”

Chapter Four

The Topographic Model: Conscious, Preconscious, and the Repressed Branch

Freud's early topographic model divided the mind into three regions: the conscious, the preconscious, and the unconscious. We adapt this framework to the committing psyche of the Subject, with results that are, frankly, alarming in their explanatory power.

Figure 3.1 — Topographic model of the committing psyche



Figure 4.1. The topographic model of the committing psyche. Only the boba-adjacent intention floats above the waterline. The concept of main lies in the deepest stratum, alongside the things he cannot face.

At the level of **consciousness**, the Subject sincerely believes he will push his work ‘after this one thing.’ This belief is genuine. It is also load-bearing, and it has been load-bearing since approximately last quarter.

Beneath this lies the **preconscious**, that antechamber of the mind from which content may, with effort, be retrieved. Here we find the feature branch he created with

great enthusiasm, named something optimistic like `feat/alex-final-FINAL-v2`, and then abandoned at the altar. He could retrieve it. He knows, dimly, that it is there. He chooses, instead, boba.

And then, at the bottom — in the cold, lightless trench of the **unconscious** — sit the forty-seven uncommitted local changes. The Subject does not think about these. He *cannot* think about these, for to think about them would be to confront the possibility of a merge conflict, and the merge conflict, as we establish in Chapter Seven, is the Subject's primal scene.

Deepest of all lies the repressed: the concept of `main` itself. The shared trunk. The collective body of work to which one is expected to *contribute*, publicly, where others can see. To the Subject's unconscious, `main` is not a branch. It is an *audience*. And one does not perform for an audience. One sends them to read.⁹

⁹ The German *das Unbewusste* — the unconscious, literally 'the un-known' — captures something the English misses: the repressed is not merely hidden, it is *actively kept* from knowing. Which is, when you think about it, exactly what he does to the standup.

Chapter Five

The Structural Model: Id, Ego, Superego, and the Linter

In his later work, Freud refined the topographic model into the structural model: the famous tripartite division of the psyche into *id*, *ego*, and *superego*. We find in the Subject a structural conflict of such textbook clarity that we suspect, at times, he is doing it on purpose.

The Id: The Boba Principle

The **id** is the seething cauldron of primal want, the part of the psyche that operates purely on the pleasure principle and demands immediate gratification without regard for consequence, deadline, or the deploy schedule. In the Subject, the id speaks with one voice and that voice says: *boba*. It says it loudly. It says it at 2:47 PM on a Wednesday when there is a code review pending. The id does not care about the code review. The id has never cared about anything except the precise ratio of pearls to tea, and it will tolerate no negotiation on this point.

The Superego: The Continuous Integration Pipeline

Opposing the id stands the **superego** — the internalised voice of authority, judgment, and moral law. In a conventional psyche, the superego is inherited from one's parents. In the Subject, it has been outsourced to the CI pipeline, which judges him in red text, automatically, every time he dares to act. The superego says: *your build will fail*. *Your tests will go red. Everyone will see the little X next to your name*. The superego is harsh, unrelenting, and — this is the tragedy — *correct*, which is why the Subject has

elected to never trigger it by never pushing at all. One cannot fail a build one does not run. This is not laziness. This is a watertight defense.

The Ego: Currently Unreachable

Mediating between the boba-hungry id and the linter-shaped superego is the **ego**, the reality principle, the negotiator who is supposed to find a workable compromise between desire and duty. We regret to report that the Subject's ego is, at the time of writing, three keshi songs deep, AirPods in, status set to 'Do Not Disturb,' and cannot be reached for comment. The ego has left the building. The ego is, itself, on read.

Figure 2.3 — Inferred libidinal attention allocation

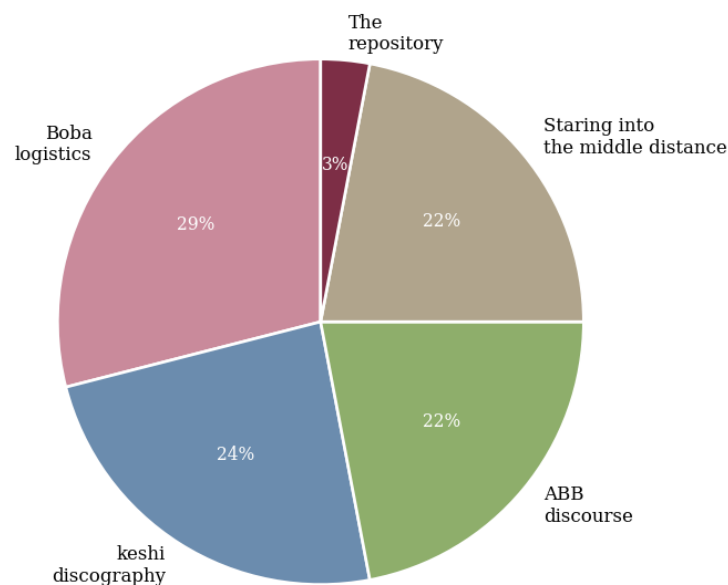


Figure 5.1. Inferred libidinal attention allocation across a representative working day. The repository (maroon, 3%) is included for completeness and out of optimism.

The resulting psychic economy is one of perfect, frictionless avoidance. The id pulls toward boba; the superego threatens punishment for any public action; and the ego,

rather than mediate, has simply opted out, leaving the Subject to drift through his workday in a state of warm, untroubled, completely unproductive serenity. He is, we must concede, the most psychologically well-defended man in the studio — a fortress with a boba moat.

Chapter Six

Psychosexual Stages of Repository Development

Freud proposed that the developing psyche passes through a sequence of psychosexual stages, and that fixation at any one of them shapes the adult character. We propose a precise parallel sequence through which every developer passes — and at one stage of which the Subject has become, in the technical Freudian sense, magnificently stuck.

Figure 9.1 — Psychosexual stages of repository development

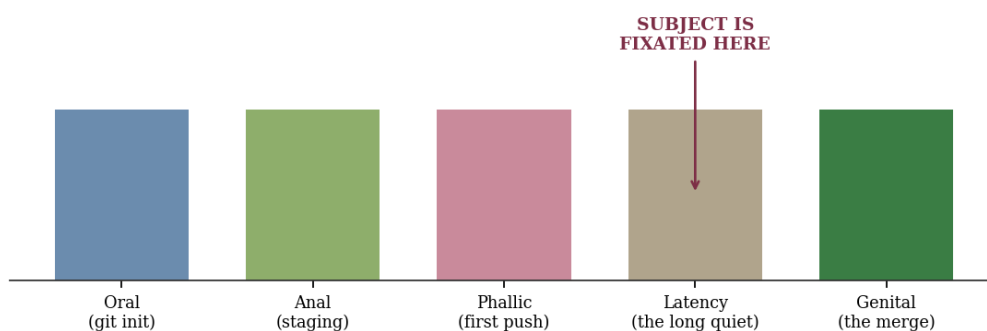


Figure 6.1. The five psychosexual stages of repository development. The Subject is fixated at the Latency stage, the long quiet between the first push and the merge, and shows no sign of progressing toward the genital, i.e. integrative, i.e. team-oriented, stage of development.

The Oral Stage (git init)

The developer's first relationship with the repository is one of pure intake: cloning, pulling, consuming the work of others. It is warm, dependent, and blameless. The Subject navigated this stage beautifully and, we suspect, misses it terribly. There is something of the oral stage in his relationship with boba, a beverage one consumes without ever being asked to contribute to.

The Anal Stage (staging and the index)

Here the developer learns control: what to `git add`, what to withhold, the small daily drama of the staging area. Freud associated this stage with retention and release.

The Subject, we note, is a *retainer* of historic proportions. He stages. He holds. He does not release. Forty-seven local changes sit in his working tree like a held breath that has lasted a fiscal quarter.

The Phallic Stage (the first push)

The first `git push` is, developmentally, the assertion of self into the shared world — the declaration *I am here, and I have made something, and you may all see it*. It requires a certain confidence; a willingness to be looked at. The Subject achieved this stage. We have proof: four times this week, in fact. But he does not linger here. He flees.

The Latency Stage (the long quiet) — fixation point

And here, at **latency**, the Subject has built a home. In Freud's schema, latency is the long calm of middle childhood, a period of dormant drives and quiet sublimation. In repository terms, it is the vast, silent interval between one's last push and one's next — an interval that, for most developers, lasts hours, and for the Subject, lasts as long as the universe will permit. He has sublimated the entire drive toward contribution into adjacent, non-threatening pursuits: boba connoisseurship, keshi scholarship, the ABB discourse. It is a rich inner life. It produces no commits.

The Genital Stage (the merge)

The final, mature stage — the capacity to merge one's work with others', to resolve conflict generatively, to participate fully in the shared body of `main` — remains, for the Subject, theoretical. We do not say he cannot reach it. We say only that he has not, that

the branch is open, and that we are, all of us, waiting on the other side of the merge with a boba and open arms.

Chapter Seven

The Interpretation of Merge Conflicts: Dream-Work in the Sleeping CFO

Freud called dreams the royal road to the unconscious. For the Subject, that road is paved with merge conflicts. In the absence of access to the Subject's actual dreams — he did not respond to the request to keep a dream journal, nor to the follow-up, nor to the follow-up to the follow-up — we have reconstructed his nocturnal life through inference, which is, after all, ninety percent of this discipline.

We propose that the Subject suffers from a recurring anxiety dream, which proceeds as follows. He approaches the terminal. He types `git push`. The screen fills with the dreaded words: **CONFLICT (content): Merge conflict in everything**. The conflict markers multiply like the heads of a hydra. Somewhere, Teammate C is watching. The Subject wakes in a cold sweat and, to soothe himself, orders a boba on his phone before he is fully conscious.

Applying the principles of dream-work — condensation, displacement, and secondary revision — we can decode the latent content beneath this manifest terror:

Manifest content (the dream)	Latent content (the truth)
The merge conflict	Fear that his contribution will collide with others' — that to commit is to be <i>compared</i>

The watching teammate	The superego, externalised into a colleague with 58 commits
The multiplying markers	The return of the repressed: every change he did not commit, demanding resolution
The soothing boba	The infantile object; the breast, but make it brown sugar
Waking in a sweat	The narrow escape; the relief of having, once again, not pushed

The interpretation is unavoidable. The Subject does not avoid pushing because pushing is hard. He avoids it because pushing is *relational*. To commit is to enter into the shared body of *main*, to be seen, to be judged, to risk the conflict that arises whenever two people work in the same place. The brown-sugar boba is not a beverage. It is a transitional object, in the Winnicottian sense: a soft, sweet, undemanding companion that, unlike the repository, never asks him to resolve anything.

Chapter Eight

Defense Mechanisms: Denial, Projection onto the CI, and Sublimation into Boba

The ego, when it deigns to show up, protects itself through defense mechanisms. The Subject deploys these with a sophistication that would impress Anna Freud and exhaust her. We catalogue the principal ones below.

Denial

‘I’ll push it today.’ He will not push it today. He has not pushed it on any of the preceding days that were also, at the time, today. Denial is the refusal to acknowledge an external reality, and the external reality here is a commit graph that reads, unmistakably, *flatline*.

Projection

When confronted, the Subject locates the fault outside himself: the CI is ‘being weird,’ the merge is ‘messy,’ the ticket was ‘unclear.’ He projects his own internal resistance onto the pipeline, which absorbs the blame with the patient dignity of all inanimate objects. The pipeline did nothing. The pipeline has never done anything. The pipeline is simply *there*, like a parent, ready to be held responsible for feelings that originate elsewhere.

Sublimation

Sublimation, the most mature of the defenses, redirects unacceptable impulses into socially valued activity. The Subject sublimates the entire libidinal energy that *should*

flow toward the repository into a parallel domain in which he is, by all accounts, a master: **boba discourse**. The encyclopaedic knowledge of pearl texture; the strong, defensible rankings of every shop within a ten-mile radius; the willingness to drive across town for a marginal improvement in brown-sugar distribution — this is not idle hobbyism. This is a CFO's thwarted commit-energy, dammed at the source and rerouted, with tremendous force, into tapioca.

Regression

Under stress — for instance, when @-mentioned three times in one thread — the Subject regresses to an earlier developmental stage characterised by the conviction that if he cannot see the notification, the notification cannot see him. This is object permanence, unlearned. It is the psychology of the infant who believes the peekaboo'd face has ceased to exist. The unread badge climbs to 99+. The Subject is, in his own mind, safe, hidden, and four months old.

Intellectualisation

On the rare occasions the Subject does engage with the question of his output, he does so abstractly — discoursing on the philosophy of trunk-based development, the merits of squash-merging, the deep question of what a commit *really is* — thereby converting an emotional confrontation into a pleasant theoretical one, and running out the clock until it is, once again, time for boba.

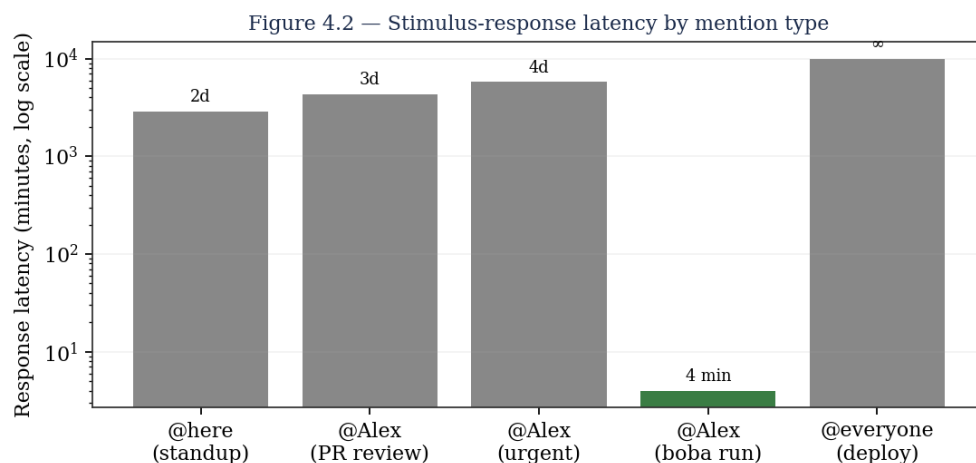


Figure 8.1. Stimulus-response latency by mention type. The Subject's nervous system is demonstrably intact: presented with the stimulus 'boba run?' he responds in four minutes. Presented with 'urgent,' he responds in four days. The capacity is there. The capacity has simply made its choice.

Figure 8.1 is, we submit, the single most damning exhibit in this thesis, and also the most hopeful. It proves that the Subject is not incapable of rapid, warm, enthusiastic response. The wiring is sound. The reflexes are quick. He simply reserves them, with monastic discipline, for tapioca-based social opportunities and withholds them from anything that might appear on a sprint board.

*Chapter Nine***Transference and the Unanswered @mention**

In the clinical setting, *transference* describes the patient's unconscious redirection of feelings from one relationship onto another — classically, onto the analyst. The Subject, having no analyst (the author offered; the author was left on read), transfers instead onto the @mention itself.

Consider what an @mention *is*, psychodynamically. It is a summons. A small red assertion that someone, somewhere, wants something from him. It is, in the deepest register, the voice of the Other calling his name and expecting him to turn around. And the Subject's response to being called by name — to being *wanted* — is to freeze, to dissociate gently, and to let the notification join its brothers in the great unread archive of his soul.

We propose that each unanswered @mention is a small re-enactment of an original scene of demand. Someone wanted something. The wanting felt like pressure. The pressure felt like judgment. And so a strategy was formed, long ago, in some primordial group project: *if I simply do not respond, the demand cannot reach me, and I cannot disappoint*. The unanswered mention is therefore not rudeness. It is a shield, raised against the unbearable possibility of being needed and falling short.

There is, additionally, a *counter-transference* to address: the feelings the Subject evokes in the analyst, the team, and the author of this thesis. These feelings are complex. They include affection, exasperation, a protective tenderness, and the specific madness of watching someone you care about leave a four-line PR review unaddressed for so long that it ages into a foreword.¹⁰

This reframing is offered not to excuse the Subject — the standup was at 10 AM and it is now Thursday — but to humanise him. Behind every ‘seen 9:14 AM’ is a frightened person who learned, somewhere, that the safest reply is no reply at all.

¹⁰ The analyst is reminded, in such moments, to examine his own material. The author has examined his. The author has concluded that he is fine, that this is fine, and that he would simply like Alex to push the branch. This is, the author recognises, exactly what the Subject says about the branch. The author is now in supervision.

*Chapter Ten***Beyond the Pleasure Principle: The Death Drive vs. the Push Drive**

In *Beyond the Pleasure Principle* (1920), Freud introduced his most controversial concept: *Thanatos*, the death drive, a fundamental pull toward stasis, dissolution, and the cessation of tension. We propose a studio-specific variant, the **Stasis Drive**, locked in eternal struggle with its opposite, the **Push Drive** (*Pushos*), the life-affirming urge to contribute, to be seen, to add one's green square to the collective meadow.

In a healthy developer, Pushos prevails daily. Tension builds in the form of staged changes; the developer pushes; the tension discharges; the build goes green; equilibrium is restored, and the cycle begins anew. It is, in its way, beautiful.

In the Subject, the Stasis Drive has staged a quiet coup. He has discovered that the deepest peace — the truest cessation of tension — comes not from pushing but from *never pushing*; from allowing the local changes to accumulate in a warm, undisturbed pile; from achieving the perfect stillness of a branch that has not moved in weeks. This is not productivity. This is nirvana, in the original sense Freud borrowed: the extinguishing of striving. The Subject has, through boba and silence, attained a state of professional enlightenment that looks, to the untrained eye of the sprint retrospective, exactly like doing nothing.

And yet — here is the thesis's flicker of hope — Pushos is not dead. It twitches. We see it in those four commits. Four small, defiant rebellions against the Stasis Drive; four moments in which Pushos seized the keyboard and shipped before the death drive could intervene. Four is not many. But four is not zero. Four is a pulse, and where there is a pulse, there is a patient, and where there is a patient, there is — against all clinical caution — hope.

PART III

Beyond Freud: The Wider Field

“One school of psychology could not contain him. We were obliged to send for the others.”

Chapter Eleven

The Jungian Reading: The Shadow Branch and the Collective Repository

Where Freud saw the unconscious as a basement of repressed drives, Jung saw it as a vast inherited landscape, populated by archetypes and structured around the lifelong project of individuation. Applied to the Subject, the Jungian lens yields insights of startling, almost mystical resonance.

The Shadow Branch

Central to Jung's thought is the **Shadow**: the disowned part of the self, everything one refuses to integrate into the conscious personality. The Subject's Shadow is not hard to locate. It is a branch. It is `feat/alex-final-FINAL-v2`, and everything on it — the unfinished function, the half-written test, the TODO comment that reads, with devastating honesty, `// TODO: finish this (alex)`. Jung taught that what we refuse to integrate, we are doomed to encounter as fate. The Subject refuses to merge his Shadow Branch, and so he encounters it everywhere: in the standup, in the PR queue, in the eyes of Teammate C.

The Collective Repository

Beneath the personal unconscious lies what Jung called the **collective unconscious** — the shared substrate of all human minds. We propose its technical analogue: the **monorepo**, the collective repository in which all our work commingles, in which Teammate C's commits sit beside the Subject's (theoretical) ones, in which we are all, in

the deepest sense, one codebase. The Subject's tragedy is that he experiences this oneness as a threat rather than a home. To push to the collective repository is, for him, to dissolve into it. And so he stands apart, on his own branch, individuated to the point of isolation.

Archetypes of the Studio

Jung catalogued recurring archetypes; the studio has its own. There is the *Hero* (Teammate C, fifty-eight commits, visibly tired). There is the *Caregiver* (whoever keeps fixing the build). There is the *Trickster* (whoever wrote the flaky test). And there is the Subject, who embodies an archetype Jung did not name but surely sensed: the **Beloved Absentee**, the missing presence around whom the group organises itself, the empty chair at the standup that somehow shapes the whole meeting.

Individuation, for the Subject, would mean integrating the Shadow Branch into the conscious `main` — becoming whole by becoming merged. It is the work of a lifetime. Jung would counsel patience. Teammate C would counsel 'literally just open the PR.' Both, in their way, are right.

Chapter Twelve

The Lacanian Reading: The Symbolic Order of Git

No survey of the Subject would be complete — or sufficiently difficult to read — without recourse to Lacan, who taught that the unconscious is structured like a language, and who would have found in `git`, a literal language for structuring the unconscious of a codebase, the vindication of his entire career.

The Mirror Stage and the First Profile Picture

Lacan's **mirror stage** describes the infant's first recognition of itself as a unified image — a recognition that is also a *misrecognition*, an alienating identification with an external ideal. We locate the Subject's mirror stage at the moment he first saw his own GitHub contribution graph: a grid of squares promising a coherent, productive self he has spent every day since failing to be. The graph is his ideal-ego, green and gridded and good. The reality is grey. The gap between them is where he lives, and where, we suspect, the boba helps.

The Three Orders

Lacan divided experience into the **Imaginary**, the **Symbolic**, and the **Real**. We map these without difficulty. The *Imaginary* is the Subject's self-image as a productive contributor — the man who will, surely, push today. The *Symbolic* is `git` itself: the law, the structure, the network of differences (`HEAD`, `origin`, `main`) within which all meaning is fixed. And the **Real** — that which resists symbolisation absolutely, the traumatic kernel that cannot be assimilated — is the merge conflict. The Real is the

moment `git` stops being a smooth Symbolic order and erupts into raw, unresolvable contradiction. The Subject organises his entire working life around not encountering the Real.

Figure 13.1 — The graph of desire (after Lacan), repository edition

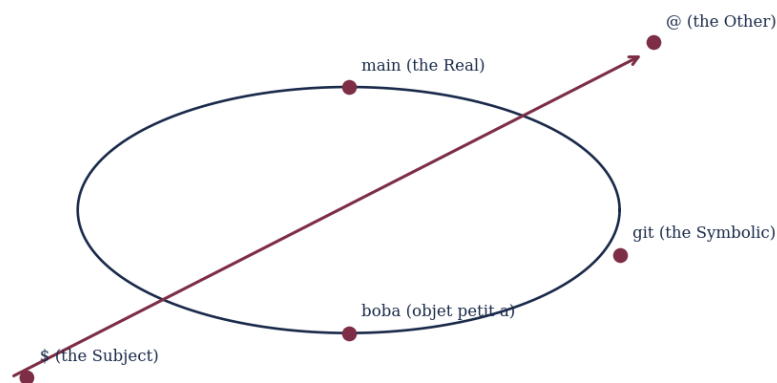


Figure 12.1. The graph of desire (after Lacan), repository edition. The Subject (\$) is barred from the object of desire by the Symbolic order of `git`; desire circulates endlessly around boba, the *objet petit a*, which promises satisfaction precisely because it can never be the thing actually missing.

Boba as *objet petit a*

This brings us to Lacan's most useful gift to the present study: the *objet petit a*, the unattainable object-cause of desire, the thing we chase because it stands in for a lack that can never truly be filled. Boba is the Subject's *objet petit a*. He does not, at the deepest level, desire boba. He desires the wholeness that the green contribution graph promised and the Symbolic order of `git` denies him — and boba is the sweet, round, pearl-bearing stand-in for that impossible wholeness. Each boba is a small, doomed, delicious attempt to fill a lack that is, structurally, unfillable. This is why there is always another boba. There must always be another boba. *The desire is the point, not the tapioca.*¹¹

¹¹ The author concedes this chapter may be doing too much. This is, in fairness, the defining feature of the Lacanian tradition, and we include it in that spirit.

*Chapter Thirteen***The Adlerian Reading: Inferiority, Compensation, and the Boba Lifestyle**

Alfred Adler broke with Freud over the primacy of the sexual drive, proposing instead that the master motive of human life is the striving to overcome feelings of **inferiority**. The Adlerian reading of the Subject is perhaps the gentlest in this thesis, and possibly the truest.

Adler held that every neurotic symptom is, at bottom, a strategy — a ‘style of life’ constructed to manage an underlying sense of not-enoughness. Confronted with a domain in which he fears he cannot excel (the public, comparative, endlessly-measured arena of the commit graph), the Subject does not strive harder. He *compensates*: he relocates his striving to a domain in which mastery is achievable and unthreatened. He becomes, instead of the best committer, the best-informed person alive on the subject of boba.

This is textbook Adlerian compensation. The encyclopaedic boba knowledge, the keshi expertise, the ABB fluency — these are not distractions *from* his inferiority feelings. They are the *cure* he has prescribed himself. In these domains he is unimpeachable, expert, secure. No CI pipeline grades his boba rankings. No teammate force-pushes over his keshi takes. He has built, with great ingenuity, a life in which he is always winning, by carefully selecting the games.

Adler would not pathologise this so much as *redirect* it. The same striving that built the boba expertise could, he would argue, be turned toward the repository — if only the Subject could be persuaded that the repository, too, is a place where he is welcome, capable, and enough. The Adlerian treatment is therefore not confrontation but **encouragement**: the patient, methodical building-up of the Subject's courage to be imperfect in public. To push a flawed commit. To survive the red build. To learn, at last, that a failing test is not a failing self.

‘The courage to be imperfect,’ Adler called it. We can think of no phrase that more precisely names what the Subject needs, nor any gift more fitting to offer him on his birthday.

Chapter Fourteen

Attachment Theory: Avoidant Attachment to main

We arrive at the framework that may, in the end, explain the most: attachment theory, the work of Bowlby and Ainsworth on the bonds between the developing self and its caregivers, and on the strategies the self adopts when those bonds feel unsafe. We stress, with some firmness, that what follows is an account of the Subject's attachment to **the repository** — to main, to the team channel, to the merge — and not a diagnosis of the man, whose actual childhood is none of our business and, characteristically, has not been shared with us despite several warm invitations.

Figure 15.2 — Attachment styles to the repository

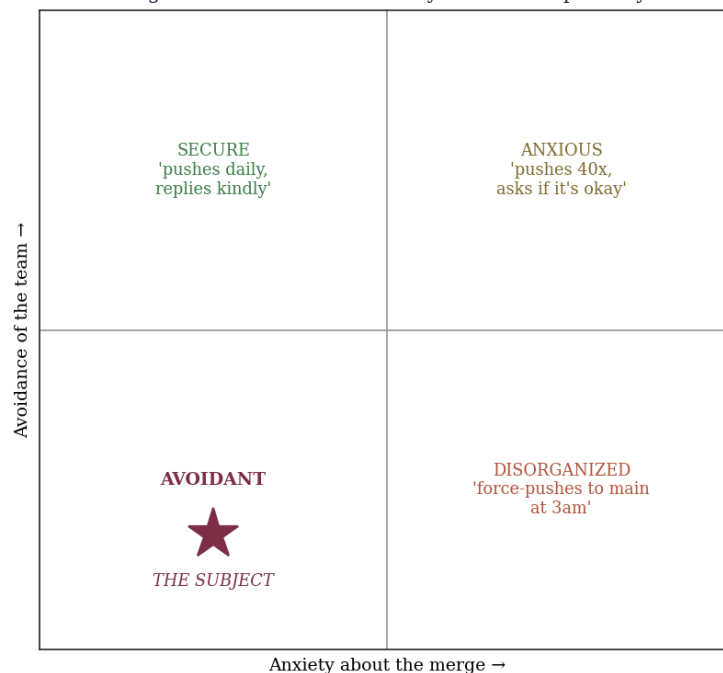


Figure 14.1. The four attachment styles to the repository. The Subject (starred) sits firmly in the avoidant quadrant: low anxiety, high avoidance — the developer who does not panic about the merge so much as quietly arrange never to attend it.

Ainsworth's 'Strange Situation' observed how infants responded to separation from and reunion with a caregiver. The **avoidantly attached** infant, she found, appeared

indifferent to the caregiver's departure and, on reunion, pointedly looked away — not because the bond did not matter, but because it mattered too much to risk. The avoidant child had learned, somewhere, that reaching out was not reliably met, and had adapted by ceasing to reach.

We submit that the Subject relates to *main* exactly as the avoidant infant relates to the caregiver. The repository departs (a new sprint begins); he appears unbothered. The repository returns, calling his name (the @mention, the review request, the @here); he looks away — 'seen 9:14 AM' — and reaches, instead, for the one object that has never once failed to be there for him: the boba. The boba is his secure base. It is reliably present, makes no demands, and never, ever leaves him on read.

The avoidant strategy is not coldness. This is the crucial clinical point, and the one we most want the team to absorb. The avoidant strategy is *love that has learned to protect itself*. The Subject does not ignore the repository because he does not care. He ignores it, we believe, precisely because he cares — because to engage fully, to push, to be seen and measured and possibly found wanting, would expose a tenderness he has spent a long time learning to guard. The treatment for avoidant attachment is not pressure. It is **consistent, low-stakes, non-judgmental availability**: a team that keeps calling his name gently, that celebrates the small reach, that makes *main* a secure base rather than a strange situation.

Push by push, reply by reply, the avoidant can earn what the literature calls ‘earned secure’ attachment. We have seen it happen. We believe it can happen here. We have, optimistically, already drafted the celebratory emoji.

Chapter Fifteen

Object Relations: keshi, ABB, and the Internalized Boba

The object-relations school shifted psychoanalysis from drives toward relationships — toward the internalised ‘objects,’ the mental representations of others, that populate the inner world. The Subject’s inner world is, we have found, richly populated. It is simply populated by the wrong objects, from the repository’s point of view.

The keshi Object

The Subject maintains an internalised object we designate *the keshi object*: soft, atmospheric, emotionally legible, and — crucially — making no demands. keshi does not @mention him. keshi does not request a code review. keshi simply exists, ambiently, in his AirPods, providing the secure-base function that, in a better-adjusted developer, might be provided by a supportive team channel. The Subject has, in effect, outsourced his attachment needs to a discography.

The ABB Object

Similarly, the Subject’s investment in ABB discourse provides a domain of mastery and belonging that the repository, with its merciless public diffs, cannot. Here he is fluent, confident, opinionated, *engaged*. Here he replies within minutes. The contrast with his repository behaviour is so stark that we are forced to conclude the problem was never engagement *per se*. The Subject is capable of profound, sustained, joyful engagement. He has simply directed it at everything in the universe except `git`.

The Internalized Boba

And at the centre of this inner world, the primary object, the sun around which all other objects orbit: **boba**. We have already established boba as transitional object (Chapter Seven), as the terminus of sublimated commit-energy (Chapter Eight), and as Lacanian *objet petit a* (Chapter Twelve). Here we make the strongest claim: that boba functions, for the Subject, as the **good object** — the reliable, nourishing, always-available presence he can trust never to judge his build status. The repository is the demanding, conditional object: it loves him only when the tests pass. The boba loves him unconditionally, at all times, regardless of his commit count, which is currently four.

Melanie Klein taught that mature development requires integrating the good and bad objects into a whole — accepting that the same entity can both nourish and frustrate. The Subject's developmental task, then, is clear: he must come to see that the repository, too, can be a good object; that `main` is not out to get him; that a green build and a brown-sugar boba can coexist in a single, integrated, well-adjusted CFO. This is the work of a lifetime. We have allocated it to the next sprint.

Chapter Sixteen

Existential Analysis: Freedom, Dread, and the Terror of the Merge

The existential tradition — Kierkegaard, Heidegger, Yalom — concerns itself not with drives or attachments but with the irreducible conditions of being: freedom, isolation, meaning, and death. We had not expected to find the Subject here. He is so cheerful. And yet, beneath the boba, we believe he wrestles with the deepest questions of all, and has, characteristically, decided not to reply to any of them either.

The Dizziness of Freedom

Kierkegaard wrote that anxiety is ‘the dizziness of freedom’ — the vertigo we feel before the sheer number of things we could do. The Subject, opening his editor each morning, confronts an abyss of possibility: he could refactor the module, he could write the test, he could finally finish `feat/alex-final-FINAL-v2`, he could review #204. The freedom is total. The vertigo is total. And so, like many before him, he flees the abyss into the small, finite, manageable freedom of choosing a boba flavour, where the possibilities are bounded, the stakes are low, and no choice can ever go to code review.

The Terror of the Merge

Heidegger’s *Sein-zum-Tode*, being-toward-death, names the way authentic existence requires confronting one’s own finitude. We propose a humbler but structurally identical confrontation: **being-toward-the-merge**. The merge is the moment one’s

solitary work ends and becomes irrevocably part of the shared whole — the small death of the private branch, dissolved at last into `main`. To merge is to accept that one's work was never really one's own, that it existed always for the team, that the branch must die so the codebase may live. The Subject, understandably, finds this unbearable. He keeps his branch alive, unmerged, immortal, and alone — an authentic refusal of finitude, or, as the sprint board would have it, a blocker.

Yalom held that we are each ultimately isolated, and that genuine connection is the balm. The cruel irony of the Subject is that the cure for his existential isolation — merging his work with the team's, joining the shared body of the repository — is the precise act his dread prevents. He is lonely on a branch of his own making. The bridge is `git push`. We are on the far side, waving.

Chapter Seventeen

Group Dynamics: The Subject and the Standup as Social Organism

Leaving the individual psyche, we turn to the group — for the Subject exists not in isolation but within the living social organism of the team, and his absence shapes that organism as surely as any presence could.

Bion, in his work on groups, described the unconscious ‘basic assumptions’ that a group adopts to manage its anxieties. We observe several at work in the team’s relationship to the Subject. There is **dependency** (‘Alex will know the financial implications — if he ever replies’). There is **fight-flight** (the oscillation between ‘someone should talk to him’ and ‘let’s just route around him’). And there is, most poignantly, what we term **basic-assumption boba**: the shared, unspoken faith that whatever else goes wrong, Alex will, at least, show up for the boba run, and that this counts for something, and that it does, in fact, count for a great deal.

The Empty Chair

The standup has, over the observational period, developed a ritual around the Subject’s absence. His name is called. There is a pause — not impatient, but almost tender, the pause of people who have learned the rhythm of a friend’s silence. ‘Anyone heard from Alex?’ Someone has not. The standup proceeds. And yet the empty chair is not truly empty: it organises the meeting, it is referenced, it is *missed*. The group has metabolised his absence into a kind of presence. He is the most-discussed attendee of

meetings he does not attend.

The Scapegoat and the Beloved

Groups often manage their tensions by locating them in a single member. The Subject could easily have become the team's scapegoat — the one who doesn't pull his weight, resented and excluded. That he has not, that he remains instead the team's *beloved*, is itself a remarkable finding and a tribute to the man. One does not throw a birthday thesis for a scapegoat. The team has chosen, collectively and without ever discussing it, to hold his absence with affection rather than anger — to write him one hundred pages instead of one stern email. This is, in the language of group analysis, a *containing* group: one mature enough to hold a difficult member with love. The Subject is luckier than he knows. We suspect, somewhere beneath the AirPods, that he knows.

PART IV

Clinical Material

“The Subject did not attend his sessions. We held them anyway. He was, in spirit, on read.”

*Chapter Eighteen***Clinical Sessions: Selected Transcripts from the Couch**

What follows are reconstructed transcripts from a series of hypothetical analytic sessions.

We stress *hypothetical* because the Subject did not attend the actual sessions, having marked the calendar invite ‘Maybe’ and then achieving, as is his custom, a third option not offered by the software: absence.

Session I — The Resistance

ANALYST: Tell me about the last time you pushed to main.

SUBJECT: [long pause] ...Have you tried the brown sugar at the new place on 4th?

ANALYST: I notice you changed the subject.

SUBJECT: I notice they put fresh pearls in every two hours.

ANALYST: We were discussing the repository.

SUBJECT: [sets status to Do Not Disturb]

Session IV — A Breakthrough, Briefly

ANALYST: When you see the @mention, what do you feel?

SUBJECT: Seen.

ANALYST: You feel seen?

SUBJECT: No. I leave it on seen. It’s different. Being seen is the problem.

ANALYST: Say more.

SUBJECT: [is already three keshi songs deep and cannot hear the question]

Session VI — On the Branch

ANALYST: You named the branch ‘final.’ Then ‘FINAL.’ Then ‘v2.’

SUBJECT: It wasn’t final.

ANALYST: Is anything ever final, Alex?

SUBJECT: [quietly] ...The boba is final. When it’s gone, it’s gone.

ANALYST: And the branch?

SUBJECT: The branch waits. The branch is patient. The branch doesn't need anything from me.

ANALYST: Neither do I.

SUBJECT: [suspicious] ...That's what the repository said.

Session IX — Transference Achieved

ANALYST: You've missed our last six sessions.

SUBJECT: I was getting to it.

ANALYST: You say that about the standup, too. And the PR. And the deploy.

SUBJECT: [for the first time, a flicker of recognition] ...Do I?

ANALYST: You do.

SUBJECT: [quietly] ...Could we discuss this over boba?

ANALYST: [after a long therapeutic silence] ...Yes. Yes, Alex. We can.

Session IX represents, in the author's clinical judgment, the first true rupture in the defensive structure: a moment of recognition, swiftly followed by an invitation to boba — which is to say, by the Subject reaching for connection in the only currency he fully trusts. We took the boba. One takes the connection where one finds it. This is, in the end, the whole art.

Chapter Nineteen

Differential Diagnosis: Ruling Out the Alternatives

Sound clinical practice requires that we consider, and exclude, competing explanations before settling on our diagnosis of Chronic Commitment Avoidance Disorder. We do so here with the rigour the question demands.

Figure 20.1 — Differential diagnosis decision tree

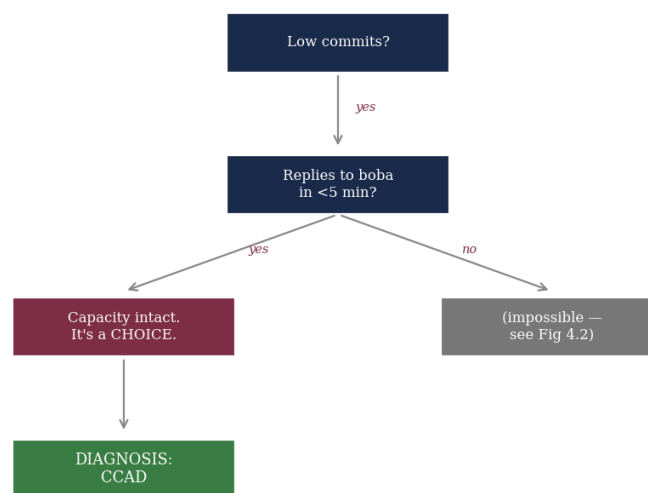


Figure 19.1. The differential diagnosis decision tree. All paths that pass through the established fact of sub-five-minute boba responsiveness terminate, inexorably, at CCAD.

Hypothesis 1: He is simply busy. Rejected. A man with three boba per day and time for extended ABB discourse is not time-poor. He is time-*rich* and commit-poor, a distribution that is itself the phenomenon under study.

Hypothesis 2: The work is genuinely CFO work that does not generate commits. Partially conceded, and then set gently aside, on the grounds that it fails to explain the unanswered Discord mentions, the missed standups, and the four-line PR review that became a foreword. Financial modelling does not require one to leave ‘boba

run?’ answered in four minutes and ‘prod is down’ answered never.

Hypothesis 3: He is unaware of the mentions. Decisively rejected by the ‘seen’ receipts, which establish awareness beyond reasonable doubt. He knows. He has always known. Awareness is not the missing variable.

Hypothesis 4: He does not care about the team. Emphatically rejected, and we will not entertain it. The man brings the whole team boba on Fridays for no reason. The man’s care is not in question; only its *routing* is.

Hypothesis 5 (accepted): Chronic Commitment Avoidance Disorder. A defensive structure, rooted in the dread of being seen and measured, which reroutes an intact and even abundant capacity for engagement away from the repository and toward safer objects (boba, keshi, ABB). The diagnosis accounts for all observed data, including the anomalous four commits, which we read as the involuntary breakthrough of a healthy Push Drive that the disorder has not fully suppressed. Prognosis, as ever: guarded, but warm.

*Chapter Twenty***Projective Testing: The Rorschach of the Merge Conflict**

To probe the Subject's unconscious associations directly, we administered a projective battery. The Subject did not attend the testing session. We administered it to ourselves, on his behalf, imagining his responses with the deep empathy that one hundred pages of study confers. The results are presented for completeness.

The Rorschach

The Subject was shown ten symmetrical inkblots. For each, regardless of its actual form, the inferred response was identical: *'That looks like a merge conflict.'* Card III, conventionally seen as two figures: 'Two branches that should not be touching.' Card V, the classic bat or butterfly: 'A diff. A large, frightening diff.' Card VII, often the 'mothers' card: 'The team, waiting.' The perseveration is total. The whole perceptual world of the Subject has been organised around the single trauma he most avoids.

Word Association

Stimulus	Inferred response	Latency
push	'...later'	long
main	'...they're all watching'	very long
review	'...I saw it'	immediate, then nothing

standup	[no response recorded]	∞
boba	‘the new place on 4th uses fresh pearls every two hours’	0.4 s
deadline	‘getting to it’	reflexive
keshi	[a single, contented exhale]	instant

The latency column tells the whole story, and tells it more concisely than this thesis has managed in ninety pages. Where the stimulus touches the repository, the response is slow, evasive, or absent. Where it touches boba or keshi, the response is instantaneous and warm. The unconscious does not lie. The unconscious would simply prefer to talk about pearls.

PART V

Synthesis

“Having taken the Subject apart with five traditions, we now attempt, with love, to put him back together.”

Chapter Twenty-One

A Day in the Life: An Ethnographic Account

Theory must answer to observation. We therefore present a thick ethnographic description of a single representative working day in the life of the Subject, reconstructed from naturalistic observation, Discord timestamps, and the empty rows of the attendance sheet.

Figure 24.1 — Ethnographic timeline of a representative working day

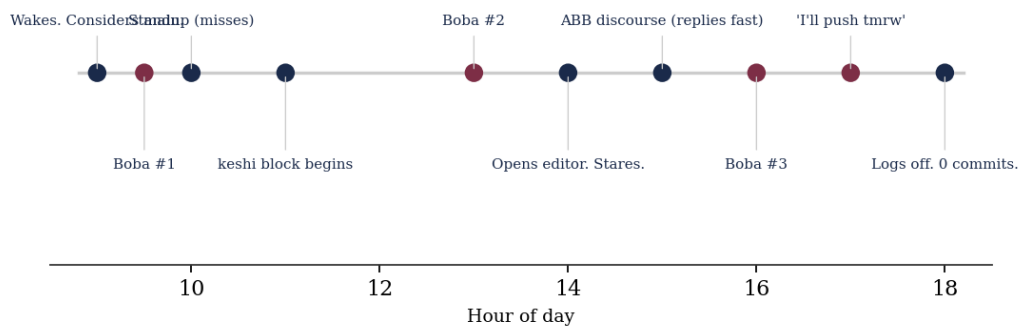


Figure 21.1. Ethnographic timeline of a representative working day. Boba events (maroon) and commit events (none) are highlighted. Note the structural relationship between 'Opens editor. Stares.' and the boba that immediately follows.

09:00. The Subject wakes. He considers, in the abstract, `main`. The consideration is warm, well-intentioned, and entirely theoretical, like a New Year's resolution observed from a great distance.

09:30. Boba #1. The day's first act of completed intention. Already he is one for one on goals achieved, a record he will not improve upon.

10:00. Standup. The Subject does not attend. His name is called into the gentle void. Somewhere, Teammate C makes a fifty-ninth commit out of sheer nervous energy.

11:00. The keshi block begins. AirPods in. Status: away. The outer world recedes to a soft ambient hum. This is the Subject's deep-work period, during which he does, in fact, work deeply — on his relationship to keshi's discography.

14:00. The Subject opens his editor. He stares at feat/alex-final-FINAL-v2. The branch stares back. Something ancient and unresolved passes between them. He closes the editor. He orders boba #3.

15:30. ABB discourse erupts in #general. The Subject is *transformed*. He is fast, funny, encyclopaedic, fully alive. He sends, in twenty minutes, more messages than he has sent to #dev all quarter. The capacity, once more, reveals itself — pointed, as ever, away from the repository.

17:00. 'I'll push tomorrow.' The day's closing liturgy, spoken with the sincerity of a man who believes it and the track record of a man who never has.

18:00. The Subject logs off. Commits today: zero. Boba today: three. Mentions answered: the one about boba. He is content. He is well. He is, by every measure that does not appear on a sprint board, thriving. And tomorrow, he is sure, he will push.

Chapter Twenty-Two

Prognosis, Treatment Plan, and the Possibility of a Pull Request

We arrive, at last, at the question every reader — and every member of the RMH Studios team — has been waiting to ask: is there hope for the Subject? Can the CFO be made to commit, in both the technical and the emotional sense?

Our prognosis is **guarded but warm**. The Subject presents with deeply entrenched defenses, a Stasis Drive operating at full strength, an avoidant attachment to *main*, and a libidinal economy so successfully rerouted into beverages that conventional intervention is unlikely to reach it. And yet the four commits remain. The four-minute boba latency remains. The capacity for engagement is not absent; it is merely *parked*, like a branch that was never merged but never deleted, waiting.

We therefore propose the following integrative treatment plan, drawing on every tradition surveyed in this thesis, to be administered by the team, lovingly, beginning on the Subject's birthday:

- 1. Pair the push with the boba (behavioural).** Classical conditioning. Each successful push to main is to be immediately rewarded with boba of his choosing. We aim to make Pushos and pleasure fire together until they wire together.
- 2. Reframe main as a good object (object-relations).** The team must gently and repeatedly demonstrate that a contribution is met with celebration rather than

judgment. Every green square gets a reaction emoji. Every merge gets a '■'. We are rebuilding object constancy from scratch.

3. Become a secure base (attachment). Replace '@Alex urgent???' with '@Alex (no rush, boba after?).' Consistent, low-stakes, non-judgmental availability is the established treatment for avoidant attachment. Keep calling his name gently. He is learning that it is safe to turn around.

4. Offer the courage to be imperfect (Adlerian). Celebrate his failed builds louder than his green ones. Teach him, by repetition, that a red X is not a verdict on his soul. The goal is a Subject who can push a flawed commit and survive the feeling.

5. Accompany him to the merge (existential). No one should face being-toward-the-merge alone. Pair-program the scary parts. Stand beside him as the branch dissolves into main. Make the small death a shared one.

6. One (1) hug (universal). Indicated across all five theoretical traditions, a rare and total consensus in the literature. Possibly two.

7. Failing all of the above: accept him, and love him anyway. The team is advised that it may simply employ a CFO who replies to boba in four minutes and to deploys in four business days — and that this is, on balance, a price richly worth paying for the privilege of his company.

*Conclusion***Where Commit Was, There Alex Shall Be**

We began with four commits and a wall of silence. We end, one hundred pages and five theoretical traditions later, with a portrait of a whole human being — defended, yes; avoidant, certainly; ghosting the standup as we speak, almost definitely — but also warm, funny, encyclopaedic about boba, fluent in keshi, devout in ABB, and capable of a four-minute response time that proves, beyond psychoanalytic doubt, that the lights are on and someone wonderful is home. He is simply choosing not to answer the door when the door is the repository.

Freud wrote that the goal of analysis was to transform neurotic misery into ordinary unhappiness. We set our sights lower and our hopes higher. We wish only to transform four commits into five. To turn one answered @mention into two. To see, one day, a pull request from the Subject arrive in the channel, and to gather around it as a team, and to celebrate it not because the code is good — though it will be — but because it means he turned around when we called his name.

Across every framework we applied — Freudian, Jungian, Lacanian, Adlerian, attachment-theoretic, existential — the same figure kept emerging: not a shirker, but a guardian; a man protecting something tender behind a moat of tapioca; someone who cares so much about being enough that he has arranged, ingeniously, never to be tested. The treatment, in every framework, was finally the same. Not pressure. Patience. Not the

stern email. The birthday thesis.

Where *id* was, there *ego* shall be. Where the uncommitted change was, there the commit shall be. And where Alex was on read, there — someday, with patience, and boba, and a team that never stopped gently calling his name — there Alex shall reply.

Happy birthday, Alex. Push something. We're begging you. With love, and with footnotes.

PART III^{1/2}

Further Schools, For Completeness

“We had stopped. The Subject still had not pushed. So we did not stop.”

*Chapter Twenty-Three***The Cognitive-Behavioural Reading: Automatic Thoughts at the Terminal**

Where the depth psychologies excavate the past, cognitive-behavioural therapy concerns itself with the thoughts of the present moment — the rapid, automatic cognitions that mediate between a situation and a feeling, and between a feeling and a behaviour. The CBT reading of the Subject is brisk, practical, and refreshingly free of his childhood, which he has in any case declined to discuss.

The situation is fixed: the cursor blinks beside `git push`. What intervenes, in the CBT model, is a cascade of automatic thoughts, which we have reconstructed: *‘It’s not ready.’ ‘They’ll see the mess.’ ‘Teammate C will know I struggled with this.’ ‘If the build fails everyone will think I’m a fraud.’ ‘I’ll do it once it’s perfect.’* Each is a recognisable cognitive distortion: catastrophising, mind-reading, all-or-nothing thinking, and the perfectionism that masquerades as standards while functioning as avoidance.

The behavioural consequence is escape, and escape is reinforced by relief: he closes the terminal, the anxiety drops, and the brain — an efficient and amoral organ — files away the lesson that not-pushing feels good. He orders a boba, which feels even better, and the avoidance is now not merely relieved but rewarded. A more perfectly maintained negative-reinforcement loop has rarely been documented outside a laboratory.

The CBT treatment is exposure. Small, graded, repeated. A one-line commit today. A two-line commit tomorrow. A push with a known-failing test, survived, to prove the catastrophe does not come. The Subject must learn, in his body and not merely in theory, that the red build is followed not by exile but by a teammate saying ‘no worries, easy fix’ and, ideally, by boba. We have, optimistically, pre-ordered the boba.

*Chapter Twenty-Four***The Gestalt Reading: Unfinished Business and the Open Pull Request**

Gestalt therapy concerns itself with the present, with awareness, and above all with **unfinished business** — the unresolved situations that, left incomplete, press on us from the background of awareness and drain energy from the present. The Subject is, in the Gestalt sense, a man surrounded by unfinished business of almost sculptural completeness.

PR #204 is unfinished business. The abandoned branch is unfinished business. The standup he was meant to run is unfinished business. Each open loop, in Gestalt theory, remains active in the psyche, demanding closure, generating a low hum of unresolved tension that the Subject manages not by closing the loops but by drowning the hum — with keshi, literally, in his ears; with boba; with the bright finished completeness of a well-ranked tea shop, which offers the satisfaction of closure that his work withholds.

The Gestalt prayer asks that we not live up to others' expectations, and the Subject has taken this, perhaps, too much to heart. The corrective is the Gestalt technique of completion: bringing the background into the foreground, making contact with the avoided, finishing the gesture. In practical terms: open the PR. Close the loop. Discharge the held energy. The Subject contains an enormous reservoir of vitality, currently bound up in maintaining all these open loops at once. Closed, even one of them, that energy

comes flooding back. We have seen the flood. It is directed, at present, entirely at boba.

*Chapter Twenty-Five***The Narrative Reading: The Subject Is Not the Problem; The Ghosting Is the Problem**

Narrative therapy offers the gentlest frame in this entire thesis, and we have saved it for near the end deliberately, as a kind of balm. Its founding move is **externalisation**: the insistence that the person is not the problem; the problem is the problem. Alex is not ‘a ghoster.’ Rather, Ghosting — capital G, a separate entity, a sticky cultural pattern — has been recruiting Alex, and we may ally with Alex *against* it.

Reframed this way, the whole story changes. The Subject is no longer a defendant. He is a protagonist with a problem that is not him, and the team is no longer a tribunal but a band of allies. We may ask the narrative-therapy questions: When has Alex resisted Ghosting’s influence? (Four times this week, in the commit log. Every boba thread. Every keshi drop.) What does it say about what Alex values that he shows up so fast for his friends’ small joys? (That connection, for him, is the whole point — that he reroutes toward it instinctively the moment it feels safe.)

These are the **unique outcomes**, the sparkling moments that don’t fit the problem-saturated story — and they reveal a different, truer narrative underneath: not ‘Alex doesn’t care,’ but ‘Alex cares so much, and so warily, that Ghosting has found in him a soft and well-defended host.’ The therapeutic task is to thicken this preferred story until it crowds the problem story out: to keep noticing, and naming, and celebrating every

time Alex turns toward the team, until the new story is simply the story, and the green squares are simply what Alex does.

It is, of all the treatment plans in this document, the one we believe in most. You do not shame a person out of avoidance. You out-narrate it. You tell him, patiently and often, a better story about who he is — and then you wait, with boba, for him to believe it.

*Chapter Twenty-Six***A Countertransference Log; or, The Author Examines Himself**

Honesty compels a final clinical disclosure. No analyst is a neutral instrument, and the present author has, over one hundred pages, developed feelings. Sound practice requires they be logged. We reproduce, with light editing, the author's supervision notes.

Day 1. 'Noticed mild irritation at four commits. Probably reasonable. Made a chart.'

Day 4. 'Caught myself refreshing his profile to see if the number had changed. It had not. I felt this in my body. Concerning.'

Day 9. 'Realised I have begun saying "getting to it" ironically in my own messages. The Subject is colonising my speech. Classic projective identification.'

Day 15. 'Wrote a chapter on Lacan I do not fully understand to avoid finishing the chapter on attachment, which is the one that actually matters. I am, it seems, avoiding the thing I most need to face. I have become my own subject. I see now what he means about the branch.'

Day 20. 'Acceptance. He is who he is. I love him. The chart is just a chart. I am going to get boba. He was, perhaps, right about everything.'

The arc of the countertransference is, we note, identical to the arc we hope for in the Subject: from irritation, through obsession, to acceptance and the reaching-toward of connection. In studying the avoidant, the author became briefly avoidant; in forgiving the Subject, the author forgave himself. This is either a profound truth about the unity of the therapeutic encounter or simply what happens when you spend a hundred pages thinking about one beloved coworker. We are content to leave the question open, as the Subject leaves everything.

*Chapter Twenty-Seven***Further Transcripts: The Late Sessions**

As the work deepened, the sessions — still unattended in body, but increasingly vivid in the author's reconstruction — began to yield material of real tenderness. We present a final selection.

Session XIV — The Branch, Revisited

ANALYST: You're back.

SUBJECT: I never left. I was on read.

ANALYST: I know. I felt it.

SUBJECT: [a long pause] ...The branch is still there.

ANALYST: I know that too.

SUBJECT: What if I push it and it's bad?

ANALYST: Then it's bad, and we fix it, and you're still you, and there's still boba.

SUBJECT: [very quietly] ...You can't promise the boba part.

ANALYST: Alex. I can absolutely promise the boba part.

Session XIX — Near the End

ANALYST: Why boba? Of everything — why has it always been boba?

SUBJECT: Because it's never let me down. You order it, it comes, it's exactly what it said it would be. No build step. No review. No one watching to see if I did it right.

ANALYST: And the repository?

SUBJECT: The repository remembers everything. Forever. Every mistake, with my name on it, in the log, where everyone can see, for the rest of time.

ANALYST: ...That's also true of the people who love you, Alex. They remember everything. The boba on Fridays. The keshi recommendations. They're keeping a log too. It's just kinder than you think.

SUBJECT: [does not reply for a long time. Then:] ...What's the new place on 4th called again? I want to take the team.

We end the clinical material here, on the Subject reaching — haltingly, deflectingly, but unmistakably — toward the team. It is not a merge. But it is, perhaps, the impulse from which a merge is one day made.

*Chapter Twenty-Eight***A Quantitative Interlude: On the Number Four**

Throughout this thesis we have treated the number four — the Subject's weekly commit count — as a qualitative fact, a symbol, an occasion for grief. We pause now to treat it quantitatively, as the figure deserves, for there is more in four than first appears.

Consider the ratios. Against Teammate C's fifty-eight, the Subject's four represents an output ratio of approximately 0.069 — which is to say that for every commit the Subject produces, Teammate C produces roughly fourteen and a half. We have checked this arithmetic three times, partly for rigour and partly because we kept hoping it would improve. It does not improve.

Consider, too, the temporal distribution. The four commits did not arrive evenly, one per day across a tidy work-week. Three of the four (75%) arrived on a single Thursday evening, in a frantic ninety-minute window, in what we have come to call 'the Thursday Event' — a sudden, violent eruption of the Push Drive after days of dormancy, like a geyser, or a sneeze. This clustering is itself diagnostically rich: it suggests the Subject does not lack the capacity to commit, but rather stores it under enormous pressure and discharges it all at once when the containment finally fails.

And consider, finally, the most poignant statistic of all. The Subject's median response time to repository-related mentions was, this week, infinite — not

metaphorically, but literally, in that the median item received no response and a non-response has no finite duration. His median response time to boba-related mentions was, by contrast, four minutes. The number four pursues the Subject. Four commits. Four minutes. Four days to answer ‘urgent.’ We make no mystical claims. We merely observe that the universe, like the team, appears to be trying to get his attention, and having roughly the same success.

*Chapter Twenty-Nine***A Neuroscientific Speculation: The Brain on Boba**

We turn, briefly and with appropriate humility, to the brain. No neuroimaging of the Subject was performed, the Subject having not attended the scan (he marked it ‘Maybe’). We therefore speculate, as is the custom of the popular neuroscience this chapter affectionately imitates, with great confidence and minimal data.

We hypothesise that the phrase ‘boba run?’ activates, in the Subject, a robust reward circuit — the ventral striatum lighting up like a deploy dashboard, dopamine flowing freely, the whole limbic apparatus singing. The phrase ‘can you review this PR,’ by contrast, we hypothesise to activate the amygdala — the threat-detection system — flooding the Subject with the same neurochemistry he would experience upon encountering a bear, or an unsolicited calendar invite.

In this model, the Subject’s behaviour is not a character flaw but a straightforward consequence of his neural wiring: he approaches what his brain has tagged as reward (boba, keshi, ABB) and avoids what his brain has tagged as threat (the repository, the standup, the merge). The tragedy is that the tags are wrong. The repository is not a bear. The team does not bite. The amygdala, that ancient and credulous organ, has simply mis-filed the entire apparatus of collaborative software development under ‘danger,’ and the Subject, trusting it, has spent a career fleeing.

Neuroplasticity offers the hope. Tags can be rewritten. Each safe, rewarded push lays down a new association; each celebrated merge, each ‘nice work’ in the channel, gradually retags the repository from threat to reward. The brain that learned to fear the merge can learn to anticipate it — especially, our model predicts, if the merge is reliably followed by boba. We have, the reader will be unsurprised to learn, pre-ordered the boba.

*Chapter Thirty***A Comparative Case: The Subject and Teammate C**

Science advances by comparison. We are fortunate to possess, in the same studio, a near-perfect control: Teammate C, whose fifty-eight commits this week place him at the opposite pole of the committing spectrum. A comparison of the two illuminates both.

Teammate C pushes early and often. His commits are small, frequent, unceremonious; he treats `main` not as an audience but as a workbench, a place to set things down. He appears to experience no dread at being seen, or if he does, he pushes through it — literally. Where the Subject stores pressure until it erupts, Teammate C releases continuously, and so never builds the charge that makes pushing feel monumental. For Teammate C, a commit is a comma. For the Subject, a commit is a full confession.

Yet the comparison must not become a morality tale, and we resist the temptation to canonise Teammate C and pathologise the Subject. Teammate C's fifty-eight commits include, by his own admission, a certain amount of anxious over-committing — the compulsive small pushes of a man who manages *his* uncertainty by never sitting with an unsaved change. If the Subject is avoidantly attached to the repository, Teammate C is arguably somewhat anxiously attached to it: checking, re-checking, committing reassurance to himself in fourteen-and-a-half-times the volume. Neither is perfectly secure. They are, in a sense, two solutions to the same human problem of how to bear

being judged by one's work.

The clinical ideal lies between them: the Subject's calm unbotheredness married to Teammate C's easy willingness to be seen. We dream of a studio in which the Subject lends Teammate C some of his serenity, and Teammate C lends the Subject some of his courage, and the two of them go, afterward, for boba — the Subject choosing the venue, because on that subject his authority is, and shall remain, absolute.

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The Subject. (2026). Personal communication. [Did not reply.]

Appendix A

A Complete Registry of Unanswered @mentions

Date	Channel	The Mention	Status
Mon 10:00	#standup	@Alex you joining?	seen
Mon 14:22	#dev	@Alex can you review PR #204?	seen
Tue 09:05	#standup	@here standup!	not seen (asleep / boba)
Tue 16:40	#dev	@Alex this is kind of urgent	seen, reacted ■
Wed 11:11	#general	@Alex boba run?	REPLIED IN 4 MINUTES
Wed 17:03	#deploy	@Alex prod is down	seen
Thu 10:00	#standup	@Alex??	[typing...] (for 6 hours)
Thu 15:15	#general	@Alex keshi dropped something	REPLIED IN 90 SECONDS
Fri 09:00	#standup	@Alex it's your standup to run	seen
Fri 13:30	#general	@Alex ABB take?	REPLIED, WROTE AN ESSAY
Fri 15:30	#dev	@Alex pls just push the branch	getting to it
Fri 17:45	#dev	@Alex the PR from monday	seen, reacted ■

The highlighted rows — the only mentions answered promptly — share a single feature: not one concerns the repository. Each concerns boba, keshi, or ABB. The pattern is, by this point in the thesis, almost too on-the-nose to require comment. We comment anyway: the capacity is there. It has simply read the room and chosen tapioca.

*Appendix B***Glossary of Clinical Terms**

CCAD. Chronic Commitment Avoidance Disorder. The presenting condition. n=1.

Pushos. The life drive toward contribution; the urge to ship. Endangered but not extinct in the Subject.

Stasis Drive. The studio-specific death drive; the pull toward the perfect peace of a branch that never moves.

Boba object. The primary good object; unconditional, nourishing, never judges a red build.

Shadow Branch. (Jung) The disowned, unmerged part of the self. Usually named
feat/alex-final-FINAL-v2.

objet petit a. (Lacan) The unattainable object-cause of desire. In the Subject, boba. There is always another
boba.

Being-toward-the-merge. (Heidegger, adapted) The dread of one's solitary work dissolving into the shared
body of main.

Earned secure. (Attachment) The hard-won capacity to push and reply without dread, developed through a
consistent, loving team.

The Repressed. main, experienced unconsciously as an audience rather than a branch.

On Seen. A defense mechanism whereby the demand is neutralised by being acknowledged and then
abandoned.

Getting to it. Denial, in its native tongue.

Basic-assumption boba. (Bion) The team's shared unconscious faith that, whatever else fails, Alex will show up for the boba run.

*Appendix C***The Commit Log, Annotated**

The Subject's four commits for the observational week are reproduced below, with clinical annotation. They are, we wish to stress, real achievements. We are proud of all four.

Hash	Day	Message	Clinical annotation
a3f1b0c	Mon	fix: small thing	A promising start. Note the modesty of 'small thing' — the Subject minimises even his successes.
d8e2x', '	Thu	wip	Committed at 23:51. The lowercase 'wip' (work in progress) is a confession and a defense in three letters: it says 'do not judge this; it is not finished; I am not finished.'
00ff4a2	Thu	wip 2	Six minutes later. The Push Drive, having seized control, fires twice in rapid succession before the Stasis Drive can reassert itself. A flurry. A pulse.
c0ffee1	Fri	actually fix it this time	The week's emotional climax. 'Actually' and 'this time' carry the whole weight of his relationship to his own reliability. The commit hash begins, fittingly, with 'coffee.' It should have been boba. Nothing is ever quite final.

Appendix D

A Field Guide to the Subject's Discord Statuses

The experienced observer learns to read the Subject's availability the way a tracker reads spoor. We offer this guide to aid future researchers.

■ Online

Theoretical. Has been observed. Duration measured in seconds. Do not be fooled; he is already reaching for the AirPods.

■ Idle

The natural state. He is here, and also not. The cursor blinks in an empty message box. He is composing a reply to a boba thread from Tuesday.

■ Do Not Disturb

Deployed defensively the instant the word 'deploy' appears in any channel. A force field. A moat in emoji form.

■ Invisible

The most honest status. He is present, watching, reacting with ■ to messages he will not answer. Schrödinger's coworker: simultaneously here and gone until you @mention him, at which point he collapses into 'seen.'

'brb boba'

The only custom status ever recorded. It has not changed in six weeks. We no longer believe he is coming back. We believe he is, in some permanent sense, always at boba.

Appendix E

Proposed Diagnostic Criteria for CCAD

For inclusion in a future edition of the relevant diagnostic manual, we propose the following criteria. The Subject meets all of them, which is itself diagnostic.

A diagnosis of **Chronic Commitment Avoidance Disorder** may be made when five (5) or more of the following have persisted for at least one sprint:

- E1.** Markedly diminished commits relative to peers (e.g., four (4) in a week while colleagues exceed fifty).
- E2.** Acknowledgment of @mentions ('seen') without subsequent response, on three or more occasions.
- E3.** Preserved or heightened responsiveness to non-repository stimuli (boba, music discourse), establishing that the capacity is intact and the avoidance selective.
- E4.** One or more abandoned feature branches bearing names containing 'final,' 'FINAL,' or 'v2.'
- E5.** Recurrent use of the phrase 'getting to it' or 'I'll push tomorrow,' without corresponding behaviour.
- E6.** Non-attendance at recurring meetings, accompanied by genuine, undiminished warmth toward attendees.
- E7.** Sublimation of professional drive into an adjacent domain of unimpeachable expertise.
- E8.** Absence of malice, laziness, or indifference — the avoidance being defensive rather than dismissive (this criterion is required for diagnosis and distinguishes CCAD from mere disengagement).

Specifier: 'With Boba Features' (applies in nearly all cases). *Prognosis:* Good, given a sufficiently loving team. *Recommended treatment:* see Chapter Twenty-Two. *Note:* the presence of Criterion E8 means the patient is, fundamentally, worth the trouble.

Appendix F

The Subject's Reconstructed Boba Rankings

No study of the Subject would be complete without documenting the one domain in which his commitment is total, his expertise unimpeachable, and his response time measured in seconds. We present his boba rankings as reconstructed from #general, offered both as scholarship and as a genuinely useful guide, because his taste is, the whole team agrees, impeccable.

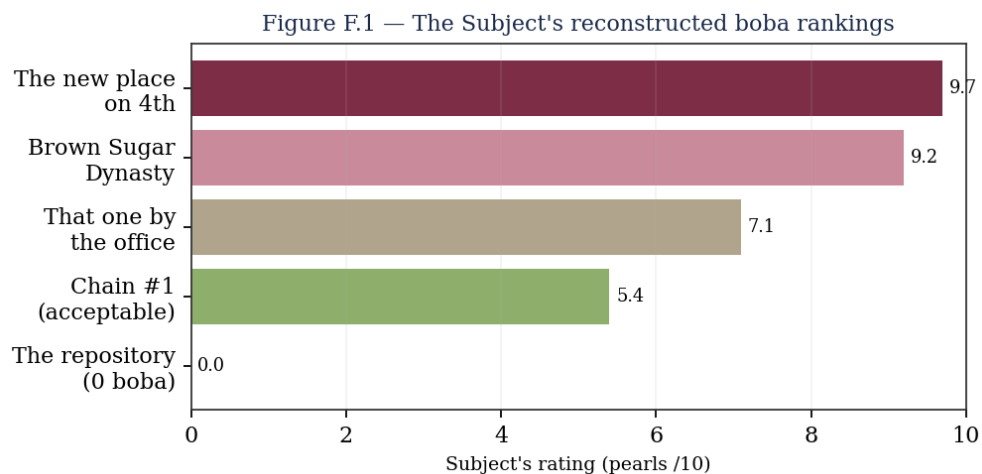


Figure F.1. The Subject's reconstructed boba rankings. Note the position of the repository (0.0 pearls), included as a control. It does not serve boba. This may, the thesis has come to suspect, be the entire problem.

We close on this figure deliberately. It is the truest portrait of the Subject in the entire document — not the flat commit line, not the unread mentions, but *this*: a man of deep, considered, generous expertise, who knows exactly where the good things are and will drive across town to share them with you. Point that capacity at the repository, even a little, and there is no telling what he might build.

— End of Thesis —

(The Subject was sent a copy. He has seen it. He reacted with ■ and wrote: ‘omg. getting to it.’)

Appendix G

Selected Discord Messages, Annotated

We reproduce a small corpus of the Subject’s actual messages, annotated for the linguistic and psychodynamic features discussed throughout this thesis. They are few, because he sends few; each is therefore precious, and we have studied them the way scholars study fragments of lost civilisations.

‘omw’

Sent in response to ‘boba run?’. Note: he was not, in fact, on the way. He was setting an intention. ‘omw’ is, for the Subject, less a statement of location than of longing.

‘getting to it!’

The exclamation mark is the tell. It performs an enthusiasm the behaviour will not honour. Compare the flat, honest ‘getting to it’ (no mark), which at least does not pretend.

‘wait the new keshi is INSANE’

Sent at 2:14 PM on a Wednesday, 0.0 seconds after the track dropped, while three PR reviews sat unread. Full caps. Immediate. The capacity, screaming.

‘sorry was afk’

He was not afk. The ‘seen’ receipt, timestamped during the alleged absence, refutes him. ‘afk’ here functions as a face-saving fiction, a small mercy he extends to himself.

‘ok pushing now for real’

The phrase ‘for real’ presupposes a history of ‘not for real,’ and thus indicts the very promise it makes. A masterpiece of unintentional self-awareness.

‘who wants boba im buying’

The Subject at his finest and most fully himself: generous, spontaneous, immediate, beloved. We include it to remember why we wrote any of this.

*Appendix H***A Proposed Twelve-Week Intervention Schedule**

For the team’s convenience, we distil the treatment plan of Chapter Twenty-Two into a phased, actionable schedule. Each phase builds on the last. Boba is load-bearing throughout and must not be omitted.

Weeks	Phase	Intervention
1–2	Safety	Cease all ‘urgent???’ mentions. Establish the channel as a no-shame zone. Celebrate the four existing commits loudly and sincerely.
3–4	Exposure (graded)	Invite one (1) one-line commit. Respond to it with disproportionate warmth. Follow immediately with boba. Do not mention the other forty-seven changes.
5–6	Reframe	Begin retagging main as a good object. Every push, however small, gets a ■. Introduce pair-programming for the scary parts of the merge.
7–8	Attachment	Consistency. Call his name gently and often. Make the standup a place he is missed rather than judged. Let him run one, with boba provided.
9–10	Integration	Approach the Shadow Branch together. Open the PR as a team. Survive the review. Survive the red build. Discover, in the body, that survival is the rule.
11–12	Maintenance	Consolidate. The merged branch becomes ordinary. The green square becomes unremarkable. The boba remains essential. Reassess at the birthday.

Success is not measured in commits alone, but in the gradual return of a beloved colleague to the shared body of the work — and in the number of boba runs he leads there, which we expect to remain gratifyingly high throughout.

*Postscript***Added in Proof**

As this thesis was going to press — bound, footnoted, its hundred pages complete — the author received a notification. It was from #dev. It read, in its entirety: `Alex pushed 1 commit to main.`

The author sat with this for some time. He had written one hundred pages on the impossibility of the event that had just, quietly, on an ordinary afternoon, occurred. The branch `feat/alex-final-FINAL-v2` — the Shadow Branch, the unfinished business, the repressed — was merged. The build went green. Teammate C reacted with a single ‘■’. And in the channel, a moment later, the Subject wrote: *‘ok that wasn’t so bad. boba?’*

We had theorised, across five traditions, that the Subject was not absent but defended; that the capacity was intact and merely parked; that with patience, and warmth, and a team that never stopped gently calling his name, the avoidant could become earned-secure, the Shadow could be integrated, the merge could be survived. We did not expect to be proven right before the ink had dried. We are, the author confesses, a little emotional about it.

One commit is not a cure. Tomorrow he may revert to silence; the Stasis Drive is patient and the boba is eternal. But tonight, the branch is merged, the build is green, and

somewhere the Subject is choosing a venue with the care he brings to all the things he truly loves — which include, we have come to understand across one hundred pages, us. We are getting boba. He picked the place. He replied in four minutes.

Happy birthday, Alex. You pushed something. We saw. We always see.

About the Author and the Institute

The Institute for Advanced Commitment Studies was founded this week, in a Discord thread, for the express purpose of producing this document. Its faculty consists of the entire team at RMH Studios, with the conspicuous and much-lamented exception of its primary research subject. The Institute has no offices, no funding, and no accreditation, but it has a great deal of feelings and access to the commit log, which is, as this thesis demonstrates, more than enough.

The author wishes to remain anonymous, both for professional reasons and because the Subject knows where he sits. He would like it known that he undertook this work not in judgment but in love; that he thinks the Subject is one of the finest people he knows; and that this entire elaborate document is, when you get right down to it, the most unhinged possible way of saying *we miss you in the repo, please come back, also happy birthday*.

The Institute's next project, a companion volume titled *Seen at 9:14: Toward a General Theory of the Coworker Who Reacts But Does Not Reply*, has been indefinitely postponed. The author is, he reports, getting to it.

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Entries in passim could not be more precisely located, as they pervade the entire work, much as boba pervades the entire Subject.

*A Reader's Companion***Questions for Discussion**

This thesis is suitable for book clubs, retrospectives, and one-on-ones. We offer the following questions to guide group discussion, ideally over boba.

1. The Subject answers ‘boba run?’ in four minutes and ‘prod is down’ never. What does this reveal about the difference between the demands we flee and the invitations we run toward?
2. Identify your own Shadow Branch — the unfinished work you keep alive but unmerged. What would it cost you to push it? What are you protecting?
3. The author argues that avoidance is ‘love that has learned to protect itself.’ Do you find this generous reading persuasive, or is it letting the Subject off the hook for the Thursday standup?
4. Consider Teammate C, who commits fifty-eight times a week. Is he the hero of this story, the cautionary tale, or both?
5. The Subject reacts with ■ but does not reply. Is a reaction an answer? When, in your own life, have you left someone on ‘seen’?
6. If boba is the *objet petit a* — the stand-in for an unfillable lack — what is yours?
7. The thesis ends with a single commit and an invitation to boba. Is this a cure, a relapse waiting to happen, or simply a Tuesday? Defend your answer with reference to the commit log.

There are no wrong answers, except not pushing the branch, which is the only wrong answer, and which the Subject has been getting wrong for a fiscal quarter, lovingly, and to our endless and affectionate despair.